

Assured.

On the One Word the Government Is Quietly Retiring

Why the rebrand from AISH to ADAP is not an administrative update — it is a confession written in the language of program administration.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Alberta Disability Income Reform Series — April 2026

ASSURED.

That is the first word of this program’s name.

Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped.

Assured.

Look at that word for a moment. Hold it.

Webster’s defines *assured* as:

made certain : guaranteed. protected against discontinuance or change. characterized by certainty or security.

Oxford adds:

confident and free from doubt. reliable. not open to question.

The word *assured* is not decorative. It is load-bearing. It is the word that tells a disabled Albertan: *this will be there. You can count on it. Build your life around it.*

This is what *assured* looks like in practice.

THE PROMISE	THE REALITY
Your income is guaranteed. You will know when it is coming. You can plan around it.	Your cheque is withheld without explanation. No call. No letter. No warning. You find out when it doesn’t arrive.
Your benefit is stable. It will not be cancelled without reason or process.	Your benefit is cancelled without notice. No prior communication. No stated reason. You are expected to figure out why.
If there are questions about your eligibility, you will be informed and given the opportunity to respond.	You are randomly audited. No trigger is explained. You are required to produce documentation for a process whose basis has not been disclosed to you.

THE PROMISE	THE REALITY
You have appeal rights. If a decision is made that affects your income, you can challenge it.	Under ADAP, appeal rights for the AISH-to-ADAP transition are removed. A government panel makes the determination. It is final.

This is not an administrative inconvenience.

AISH is not discretionary income. For the people who receive it, it is the margin between housing and homelessness. Between medication and crisis. Between stability and collapse.

A cheque that doesn't arrive is not a paperwork problem. It is a rent payment that bounces. It is medication that doesn't get filled. It is a parent who cannot tell their children why there is no food.

A benefit cancelled without notice is not an administrative oversight. It is a medical crisis waiting to happen. It is a person with a disability, who cannot work, who woke up this morning with no income and no explanation.

When income that a disabled person cannot replace disappears without notice, the consequences are not administrative. They are medical. They are physical. They are, in some cases, fatal.

Zero prior communication before a benefit change is not a gap in customer service. It is negligence. It is a system that has decided the administrative cost of notifying people is worth more than the physical cost of what happens to them when they are not notified.

And now they are changing the name.

ADAP. Alberta Disability Assistance Program.

Notice what is missing.

The word *assured* is gone.

The government is not keeping the promise. So it is retiring the word that made it.

ADAP makes no claim of assurance. No claim of guarantee. No claim of stability or reliability or certainty. It makes no promise at all. It simply describes a program category and expects you to infer the rest.

*This is not accidental. **A government that was keeping the promise would not need to remove the word.***

What should it be called?

If the name of a program is going to reflect its documented function rather than its aspirational promise, there is a more accurate option.

ADVERSATIVE INCOME FOR THE SEVERELY HANDICAPPED

adversative | *adj.* | expressing opposition or antithesis; working against

Adversative. Working against. In opposition to.

A program that withholds income without explanation is working against the people it serves.

A program that cancels benefits without notice is working against the people it serves.

A program that audits without cause and removes appeal rights is working against the people it serves.

A program that removes the word *assured* from its name because it can no longer defend the promise is working against the people it serves.

The name change from AISH to ADAP is not a rebrand. It is a confession. The government is telling you, in the language of program administration, that it is no longer willing to assure you of anything.

What *assured* was supposed to mean

Assured meant something.

It meant that a disabled Albertan could wake up on the first of the month and know their income would be there. That they would not have to chase it. That they would not have to prove, again, that they are still disabled. That they would not be cancelled without cause or warned without time.

It meant that the floor would hold.

AISH never fully kept that promise. The random audits, the withheld cheques, the silent cancellations — those happened under the word *assured* too. But the word at least acknowledged the obligation. It named what the program was supposed to be.

ADAP doesn't name an obligation. It names a category.

*There is nothing assured about any of this. There never fully was. **And now they have stopped pretending.***

And there is one more thing *assured* was supposed to mean.

It was supposed to mean that the people receiving this income could speak about it. Could report problems with it. Could advocate for themselves within it. Could contact their MLA, write to the minister, tell their story publicly — without fear that doing so would trigger a review, a reduction, or a cancellation.

That is not what recipients experience.

What recipients experience is this: a program they depend on for survival, administered by workers they cannot easily reach, with decisions they cannot easily appeal, and consequences they cannot easily recover from. A program where the power differential between recipient and administrator is total. Where the person asking the question has everything to lose, and the person answering it has nothing.

In that environment, fear is not irrational. It is accurate. It is the correct read of a situation where speaking up has a documented cost and staying silent has none — at least not immediately, not visibly, not in a way that can be traced back to the silence itself.

The silence is not a choice. It is a symptom.

A program that genuinely *assured* its recipients would not produce recipients who are afraid to speak about it. The fear itself is evidence. It is the clearest possible signal that what is being received is not assurance — it is dependency. And dependency and assurance are not the same thing.

Assurance means: you can speak. You can question. You can push back. And the floor will still hold.

Dependency means: you cannot speak. Because the floor is the only thing between you and the drop. And the floor belongs to someone else.

Assured means the floor holds even when you push back. What 79,290 Albertans have is not assurance. It is a dependency they are afraid to question. That fear is the confession the word ADAP forgot to make.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

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